

Frequently Asked Questions FAQs

1. What is a PET Scan?

A Positron emission tomography (PET) scan is an imaging test which uses a safe, injectable low dose radioactive chemical called a radiotracer to reveal the metabolic or biochemical function of your tissues and organs. A PET scan can often detect the atypical metabolism of the tracer in diseases before it shows up on other imaging tests, such as computed tomography (CT) and magnetic resonance imaging (MRI). It may help doctors find out:

- Detecting cancer.
- whether a lump is cancerous (malignant) or non-cancerous (benign)
- whether the cancer has spread to other parts of the body (Metastasis)
- Response to the treatment.
- Finding a cancer recurrence.

2. What documents are supposed to be presented to book for the scan?

A duly filled NHIF form – for Kenyan residents

- A doctor's request form indicating dates of last chemotherapy, radiotherapy and surgery.
- A biopsy report.
- Recent CT scan/ MRI reports and a copy of the patient's ID.
- For a person under 18, their birth certificate is to be presented

3. Why am I supposed to present the documents for a booking to be done?

They give the doctor the medical history of the patient, which is very useful in giving a concise report.

4. Is the PET/CT done on appointment or can I just walk in?

The PET/CT is only done on an appointment basis.

5. Does NHIF cover the cost of the scan?

Yes. NHIF fully pays for the FDG scan (General Oncology cases) and partially for the PSMA scan (Prostate Cancer). whereby NHIF covers Ksh 50,000 and the patient tops up Ksh 10,000

6. How long does NHIF take to give approval?

NHIF approval takes about 48-72 hours (about 3 days) to approve.

7. What is the patient supposed to do on the day of the scan?

The patient is to be on a fast of at least 6 hours. This means that they are not to take breakfast on the morning of the scan. You can consume plain water.

8. What time should the patient arrive on the day of the scan?

The patient is advised to come at 6 A.M. as the system is on a first come first served basis.

9. When can I pick the report?

The report is usually ready within 2 working days excluding the day of the scan.

10. Should I be accompanied on the day of the scan?

It is not compulsory, but the patient can be accompanied on the day of the scan. However, the person is not allowed in the room during the scan.

11. Can a relative/friend do the booking on behalf of the patient?

Yes. The person needs to have all the documents required for booking.

12. Can a relative/friend pick the report on behalf of the patient, or can the report be sent via email?

Yes. This can be organized by the report collection team.

13. Who should I contact if I have more questions?

One can call 011-113-8106 | Email imagingcentre@kutrrh.go.ke . You can visit Integrated Molecular Imaging Centre (IMIC) front desk for further clarification.

14. What should I do if I have a specific medical condition or allergy?

Inform the medical staff of any specific medical conditions or allergies before the scan. They need this information to ensure that the scan is conducted safely and to adjust any procedures if necessary.

15. What if I'm claustrophobic (Anxiety of confined spaces)?

If you are claustrophobic, inform the staff beforehand. They can provide support and discuss options to help you feel more comfortable during the scan.

16. Can I chew gum or have breath mints before the scan?

No, you should avoid chewing gum, breath mints, or candies before the scan, as they can affect the scan results.

17. What should I do if I am pregnant or think I might be pregnant?

If you are pregnant or suspect you might be, inform the medical staff immediately. PET scans involve radiation, which could be harmful to a developing fetus. Your healthcare provider will discuss alternative imaging options if necessary.

18. What happens if I miss my appointment?

If you miss your appointment, you should contact the imaging center as soon as possible to reschedule.

19. Will I feel any pain during the PET scan?

The PET scan itself is painless. The injection of the tracer might cause a slight discomfort or a feeling of warmth, but it's usually brief.

20. How often can I have a PET scan?

The frequency of PET scans depends on your medical condition and your doctor's recommendations

21. Will the PET scan affect any metal implants or devices in my body?

PET scans generally do not interfere with metal implants or devices. However, inform the nurses about any implants or devices, as they can provide specific guidance based on your situation.

22. What should I do if I experience a reaction to the tracer?

If you experience any unusual symptoms or allergic reactions following the injection of the tracer, please inform the healthcare provider immediately.

23. Can PET scans be used for pediatric patients?

Yes, PET scans can be used for children, but they are typically performed with caution due to the radiation involved. Pediatric patients may require minimal sedation and special protocols to keep the radiation exposure to the lower limit.

24. How long does a PET scan take?

The whole procedure, including preparation, injection and scanning takes approximately around 2 – 3 Hours. There might be slight variations for SPECT scans depending on the injectable tracers.

25. How does a PET/CT scan differ from a CT scan?

A CT scan only evaluates the anatomical structures of your body. Whereas the PET adds detailed metabolic / functional information of an organism. By combining the information about body's anatomy and metabolic function, a PET/CT scan provides a more detailed picture of the cancerous tissues than either test does alone. The PET and CT images appear in a single scan (fused image) allowing for a higher level of accuracy.

26. Are family members allowed to be with me during the procedure?

No. The PET/CT scan requires the administration of a radioactive isotope. For this reason, portions of the office are restricted and can only be occupied by the patient and the authorized medical personnel.

27. Should I be concerned about radiation during a PET/CT scan?

Like any other ionizing radiation diagnostic tests, PET/CT scans also involves radiation exposure to the patient and healthcare workers in the department. However, our doctors calculate the dose to be as low as reasonably achievable (ALARA principle) to get the optimal scans. Your Oncologist has ordered a PET scan because he or she feels the benefits of the scan far outweigh any small risks associated with low levels of radiation associated with the scans.

28. Is a PET/CT scan considered therapy?

No, a PET/CT scan is a diagnostic test. The results of a PET/CT scan help your Oncologist determine their treatment decisions.

29. Will the injection from a PET/CT scan affect my blood glucose level?

Although FDG is very similar to glucose, the amount injected is so small it will not affect your blood glucose level.

30. Can I read, use my cell phone or watch TV while I am in the waiting room?

The PET/CT scan is so sensitive that it can even be affected by eye motion, head motion, or stimulation during the “uptake phase”, which is the time immediately following your injection. The recommendation is for you to rest quietly in a dimly lit room during this ‘uptake phase’ after injection to obtain the best possible image quality.

31. Is it important to tell the nurse if I ate in the last 6 hours?

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32. What should I expect when I come in for a PET scan?

At the scanning department, you may be asked to change into a hospital gown. The department staff may also ask you to remove any jewelry or objects containing metal. This includes:

- piercings
- hair clips
- zips

- your bra.

This is because the metal in these objects can affect the picture made by the scanner.

About 1 hour before the scan, the radiographer will inject a small amount of a radioactive substance through a cannula into a vein in your hand or arm. This substance is called a radiotracer. While you wait to have the scan, the radiographer will encourage you to drink water.

This helps in tracer distribution throughout the body and gets concentrated in the region of interest.

Very rarely, some people are allergic to the tracer. This can make them feel breathless, sweaty or weak. Tell the radiographer / nurse immediately if you experience such symptoms.

33. What should I do after the PET scan?

You can go home after the scan. The amount of radiation used is small. But the radiographer will advise you not to have close contact with pregnant people, babies and young children –under 7 years for 12 hours after the scan. After this, the radioactive substance will have passed out in your urine (pee) therefore encouraged to hydrate frequently.

34. Is there any special preparation for diabetic patients?

Yes, diabetic patients should not consume any food or drink other than plain water for at least 6 hours before the scan. They should avoid coffee, tea, cola drinks, and alcohol for 24 hours before the scan. They should not take diabetes medications or insulin the morning of the scan but can take other non-diabetes medications after consulting the doctors.